Budget Management for College Students

Budgeting tips and financial literacy basics

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Why budgeting matters

1

Know your money

Most students underestimate small, repeated spending like food delivery and subscriptions.

2

Avoid stress

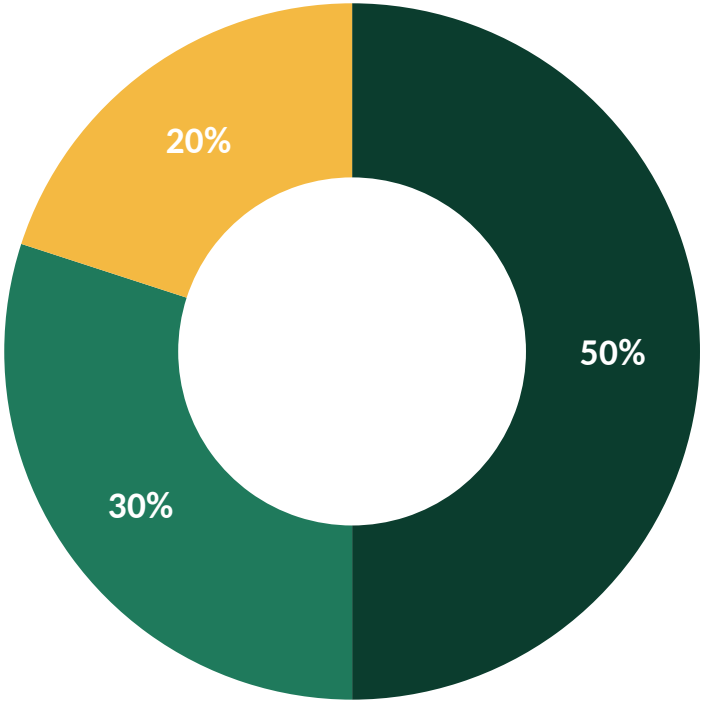
A plan means fewer end-of-month surprises and less borrowing from friends or credit cards.

3

Build habits early

Habits formed now carry into your first job, rent, and long-term savings.

The 50/30/20 rule

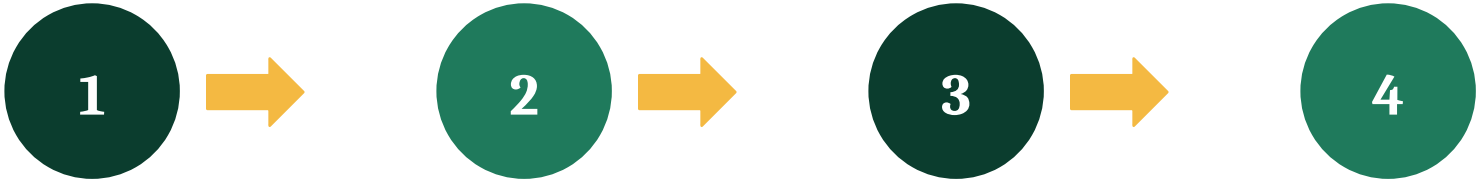


50% — **Needs**
Rent, groceries, transport, tuition, phone

30% — **Wants**
Eating out, entertainment, shopping, trips

20% — **Savings**
Emergency fund, goals, paying off debt

Track your money in 4 steps



Income

List allowance, salary, scholarships

Fixed costs

Rent, tuition, phone, insurance

Variable costs

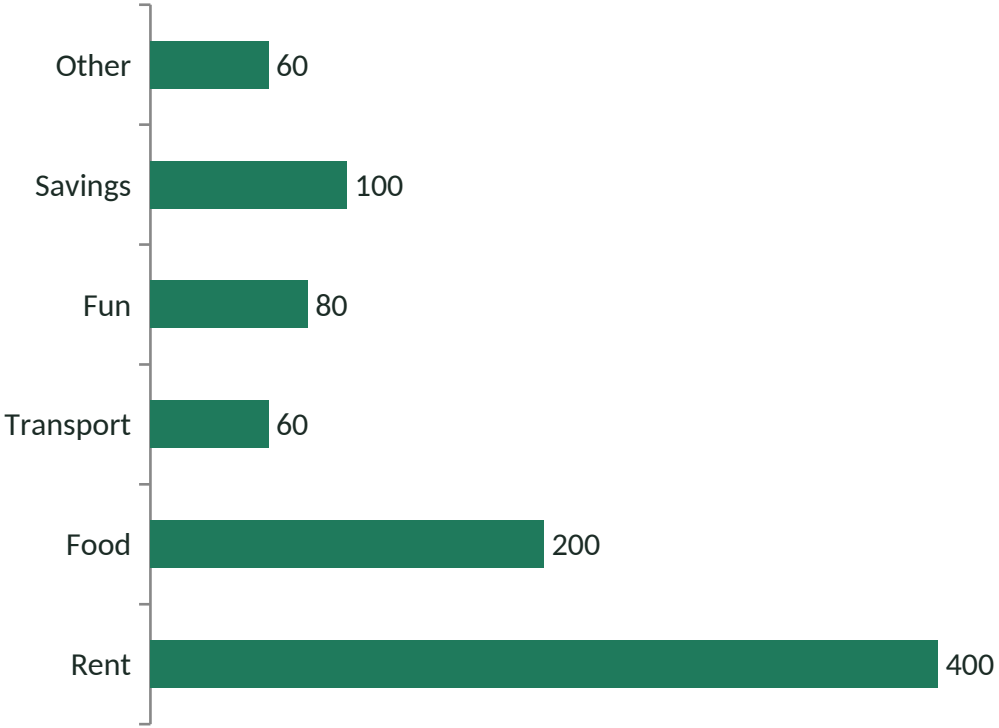
Food, transport, fun, shopping

Review

Compare plan vs actual each week

Tip: use the Excel budget sheet to log every expense by category.

Sample monthly budget



$900

example monthly income

Every dollar gets a job: expenses plus savings equal income.

Set savings goals that stick

Make goals SMART

Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound

Pay yourself first

Move savings out the day income arrives, before spending.

1. **Emergency fund**
   Aim for 1 month of expenses first
2. **Laptop upgrade**
   Save a fixed amount monthly for 6 months
3. **Trip or event**
   Set a target and a date

Cut unnecessary expenses

Food

Cook in batches, limit delivery

Subscriptions

Cancel what you rarely use

Textbooks

Rent, buy used, or share

Transport

Use student passes, walk or cycle

Shopping

Wait 24 hours before buying

Social

Pick free or low-cost plans

Financial literacy basics

Credit score

Pay on time and keep card use low to build it.

Interest

Compounding helps savings but hurts debt.

Emergency fund

Cover surprises without borrowing.

Scholarships & aid

Apply every term and read the terms.

Smart money habits

1	**Weekly check-in**	10 minutes every Sunday to review spending
2	**Student discounts**	Ask for them; use ID and campus deals
3	**Cash limit**	Set a weekly fun budget and stop at zero
4	**Budget app or sheet**	Log expenses the same day

Key takeaways

1. Plan every month: income minus expenses
2. Save first, spend what is left
3. Track weekly and adjust
4. Learn credit and interest early

Thank you